

Colombia



Lying in northwest South America, Colombia has coastlines on both the Caribbean and the Pacific. It is primarily noted for its coffee, emeralds, gold, and cocaine trafficking.



GEOGRAPHY

The densely forested and almost uninhabited east is separated from the western coastal plains by the Andes, which divide into three ranges (*cordilleras*) with intervening valleys.



CLIMATE

Coastal plains are hot and wet. The highlands are much cooler. The equatorial east has two wet seasons.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Colombians are of mixed blood. Blacks and Amerindians have the least political representation. Civil conflict over four and a half decades has displaced millions of people, and left over 200,000 dead. The fighting is deeply entwined with the narcotics trade. Violent crime is common.



INSIGHT: Over 50% of the world's cocaine is produced in Colombia



THE ECONOMY

Healthy and diversified export sector – includes coffee and coal. Considerable growth potential, but drugs-related violence and corruption deter foreign investors.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Colombia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1819

CAPITAL: Bogotá

POPULATION: 45.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 439,733 sq. miles
(1,138,910 sq. km)

DENSITY: 114 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Wayuu, Páez, other Amerindian languages

RELIGIONS: Catholic 95%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 58%, White 20%, European-African 14%, African 4%, African-Amerindian 3%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Col. peso = 100 centavos